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Christian Nationalism in Modern Ethiopia

Understanding religious-nationalistic tendencies in Ethiopian Church, State & Society

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Acronyms

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EFGBC	Ethiopian Full Gospel Believers' Church
EIASC	Ethiopian Islamic Affairs Supreme Council
EOC	Ethiopian Orthodox Church
EPRDF	Ethiopian People's Revolutionary Democratic Front
FDRE	Federal Democratic Republic of Ethiopia
TPLF	Tigray People's Liberation Front

1. Introduction

Christian nationalism is not a subset of conventional Christianity, but a framework that fuses religious identity with ethno-nationalist sovereignty, seeking to institutionalize social dominance for a specific cultural group. It is principally concerned with political influence, proprietary claims over state identity, and the demarcation of social boundaries between "us" (the righteous citizens) and "them" (the existential outsiders) (Whitehead and Perry, 2020, pp. 58, 87). While extensively documented within North American and European contexts, Christian nationalism has increasingly manifested as a global political phenomenon. In Ethiopia, this dynamic has assumed a highly idiosyncratic form with state governance synthesizing charismatic providentialism and strong economic positivism under its Pentecostal movement.

Pentecostalism in Ethiopia, called P'ent'ay (ጴንጤ), ranges from established denominations to independent fellowships that cater to a rising middle and upper class in urban centres like Addis Ababa, Bonga or Gambela.[1] This growth is fueled by a message of spiritual renewal and healing, resonating in a time of rapid change and uncertainty. Central to its appeal is an approach that links personal faith with economic transformation, encouraging entrepreneurialism and a break from traditional kinship obligations (Østebø, 2025, p. 68).

The most dramatic shift is its new political prominence. This was unimaginable under the secular Ethiopian People's Revolutionary Democratic Front (EPRDF) until 2019, but it became the norm under the current Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed Ali, a self-proclaimed "born-again" Pentecostal (Østebø, 2025, p. 63f.). Abiy openly uses religious rhetoric, framing national development and prosperity in biblical terms.[2] The new ruling party of the Ethiopian State which replaced the EPRDF, the Prosperity Party (ብልጽግና ፓርቲ), is a direct nod to the prosperity gospel ideas that have taken root in Ethiopian society through this political Pentecostal shift (Østebø, 2025, p. 73).

The movement's aggressive proselytism has also worsened relations with the Ethiopian Orthodox Church (EOC) and Muslim communities guided under the Ethiopian Islamic Affairs Supreme Council (EIASC). The very political rhetoric that promises abundance can further absolve the state of responsibility during times of conflict and displacement (Østebø, 2025, p. 74). In essence,

[1] For the religious distribution across the country, see: (Figure 2: Religion in Ethiopia).

[2] Albeit a sharp contrast to his predecessors, this phenomenon is increasingly common with other global leaders, e.g., the incumbent President of the United States of America, Donald Trump, and his post-assassination rhetoric (Kruse, 2025, para. 1f.).

P'ent'ay today has moved from the margins to the center of national life, becoming a force that links the country's political landscape and civil society. So what defines P'ent'ay and how was it effectively transformed into its own form of Christian nationalism?

2. Framework & History of Ethiopian P'ent'ay (ጴንጤ)

The aim now lies in exploring where the movement came from and to map out how it is structured and used today. Pentecostalism is a branch of Protestantism in Christianity. In Ethiopia the particular formation of that Pentecostalism, P'ent'ay, has seen its followership grow from 5% to approximately 20% of the population since the year 2000 (Haustein, 2013, p. 349). It finds its roots in Finnish initiatives which began in 1951 to establish an organization for its missionaries. By 1956, a work centre in the Addis Ababa Merkato area began conducting meetings that attracted Ethiopian students. Second to the Finnish was the Swedish Philadelphia Church Mission which established a congregation in Awasa in 1960. Annual summer Bible schools increasingly attracted youth from across the country to these congregations in the 1960s (Haustein, 2013, p. 349f.).

By the mid-1960s, an indigenous movement also gained momentum as young Ethiopians, partly connected to the mentioned missions, formed local, independent prayer groups. These various initiatives eventually led to a national convergence into the Mulu Wongel Amagnoch Church (**የኢትዮጵያ ሙሉ ወንጌል አማኞች ቤተክርስቲያን**)[3] by 1967 (Haustein, 2013, p. 350). An official religious registration however was denied by the Imperial Emperor Haile Selassie in accordance with the EOC. This led to a closure of meeting places, shifting the movement mostly to private homes. Due to this the movement survived the following Socialist Derg (**ደርግ**)[4] purges against religion with relatively little trouble, as it was already withdrawn from society and the Derg focused on cracking down on more dominant religious institutions. After the fall of the Derg in 1991 the movement started to progressively flourish in the new secular Federal Democratic Republic of Ethiopia (FDRE) (Haustein, 2013, p. 351).

A central figure in the narrative of P'ent'ay's origins is Chacha Omahe, a Kenyan evangelist who visited Ethiopia briefly in 1963, 1964 and 1966 (Haustein, 2013, p. 352). His role is applied to the context of the movement in several ways. In the first written history of the movement by

[3]Translation: Ethiopian Full Gospel Believers' Church (EFGBC), see: (Figure 1: Logo of the EFGBC).

[4]Translation: Committee.

Tormod Engelsviken, Chacha is portrayed as the ”spark” that set the ground of the movement. This narrative emphasizes mission independence, arguing that while outside missions provided groundwork, the actual outpouring of the Spirit was conveyed by ”one of Africa's own black sons” (Engelsviken as in Haustein, 2013, p. 353f.), quasi-functioning as a symbol of national emancipation. Although he was well established in the Kenyan Pentecostal scene at the time, with ties to American missions, such a narrative ignores his background and collapses all three visits into a single, miraculous ”outpouring” event. Haustein (2013) identified this as a problem and argues that it is imperative to move beyond only reconstructing such past events and rather fully analyze how historical narratives themselves are constructed and used. He draws upon four key theoretical pillars of argumentation to solidify this idea.

Firstly, narrativity and emplotment (White as in Haustein, 2013, p. 352). This argument proposes that historical events do not exist outside of language, they only become ”historical” once interpreted through narrative structures. White suggests that historians use ”emplotment”, meaning literary plots like Romance, Tragedy, and ideological implications, to give formal coherency to the past (White as in Haustein, 2013, p. 354f.).

Secondly, the stem of the empty signifier (Laclau and Mouffe as in Haustein, 2013, p. 356). In discourse theory an ”empty signifier” is a term or event that loses its details to represent a broader identity, like ”freedom” or ”justice”. This process is a hegemonic operation, used to fix meaning within a fragmented discourse (Laclau and Mouffe as in Haustein, 2013, p. 357ff.).

Next is the genealogy and disparity of origins (Foucault as in Haustein, 2013, p. 360). Rather than searching for a single ”origin”, the theory here seeks to recover the accidents, errors, or deviations that lead to the present. This treats history as an operation that exposes the contingency of historical knowledge (Foucault as in Haustein, 2013, p. 361f.).

Lastly he mentiones the concept of iterability and differance (Derrida as in Haustein, 2013, p. 363). By this logic writing is ”iterable”, meaning it can be repeated in new contexts, which continuously defers and transforms historical meaning. History is therefore a project for the present and future, never fully reaching a final version (Haustein, 2013, p. 363f.).

Now, how are these theories applied to the Ethiopian context and the role of the Kenyan evangelist Chacha Omahe? The already mentioned narrative of mission independence with Tormod Engelsviken's 1975 ”Documentary Report” used the story of Chacha to create a plot of na-

tional emancipation. In this narrative, outsider missionaries only provided ”groundwork”, while Chacha provided the true ”spark” of the Holy Spirit that led to an independent indigenous church (Haustein, 2013, p. 353). As such he transitioned from a normal historical person to a literary figure used to define the origins of P'ent'ay. These origins as such help the proliferation and consolidation of the movement to drive a confluence of socio-cultural, political, and institutional mechanisms which gave rise to its transformation into a form of Christian nationalism.

Such movements flourish during periods of perceived cultural decay, demographic shifts, or acute socio-political disintegration. These existential anxieties can be weaponized, framing social transformations as deliberate attacks on traditional heritage and sacred order (Gorski and Perry, 2022, pp. 25)(Whitehead and Perry, 2020, pp. 64, 87). In Ethiopia, decades of ethnic federalism under the EPRDF generated inter-ethnic friction and urban fear, creating fertile ground for a unifying rhetoric that promised national redemption (Gardner, 2024, pp. 24, 44)(Østebø, 2025, p. 65). Further, the rapid expansion of prosperity theology and active engagement with public life has provided a potent ideological engine for political mobilization (Gardner, 2024, p. 44)(Østebø, 2025, pp. 63, 65ff.). Moreover, autocratic and populist leaders leverage Christian nationalist language to bypass formal democratic institutions, presenting their political mandates as divinely ordained mandates (Gardner, 2024, pp. 205, 308)(Whitehead and Perry, 2020, p. 87). Prime Minister Abiy's self-identification of having a higher purpose illustrates how personal ambition is sanctified through messianic authority. Within this framework, socio-economic crises are reinterpreted not as structural failures, but as mental deficiencies that can be overcome through positive confession and spiritual affirmation (Østebø, 2025, p. 76)(Gardner, 2024, pp. 206f.).

To finalize the framework, methodologically Haustein (2013) concludes, that critical historiography should not aim for the ”real story”, but instead sustain the plurality of historical memories by investigating the political and literary forces that shape them. The job is not to describe a certain moment, but to examine how different narratives were woven together, which were prioritized and which marginalized or trimmed away (Haustein, 2013, p. 365).

3. Creating *God Incarnate*

Incumbent Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed's political career and personal worldview is rooted in such a narrative. He frequently talks of his experiences during the 1998-2000 Ethio-Eritrean War near the frontlines at Badme. Here, he retells, he narrowly escaped death when his foxhole suffered a

direct strike from Eritrean artillery (Gardner, 2024, p. 43). Having briefly stepped away from his post to position an antenna, he returned to discover that his entire squad had been wiped out, leaving him as one of the sole survivors to radio military headquarters in Addis Ababa (Gardner, 2024, p. 43f.). Rather than interpreting this event as luck, he conceptualized his survival as a direct act of divine intervention. This experience catalyzed his conversion to P'ent'ay and the EFGBC (Gardner, 2024, p. 43ff.). He marked this event as a shift toward the conviction that god had spared his life for a specific mission to lead and redeem the Ethiopian nation, reinforcing the "prophecy", that he would one day reign as the "seventh king" (Gardner, 2024, pp. 3, 43, 49, 71). Abiy relocated to Addis Ababa after the war to work at a regional security agency under the patronage of defence minister Abadula Gemeda (Gardner, 2024, pp. 46, 52). During this period, he married Zinash Tayachew, a former soldier, who established herself as a popular Pentecostal gospel singer (Gardner, 2024, p. 46).

Pastors and religious institutions in Ethiopia categorize Abiy's narrative adhering to Dominionist theology, which encourages Christians to occupy key societal "mountains", including politics, business, media, and culture, to advance the "Kingdom of God" (Østebø, 2025, p. 69)(Gardner, 2024, p. 47). This posture stands in contrast to his predecessor, Prime Minister Hailemariam Desalegn. While Hailemariam was also a devoted Christian, he adhered to constitutional secular limits and operated within the collective discipline of the government, keeping religious rhetoric out of official affairs (Gardner, 2024, p. 48). Abiy, conversely, rejected these secular boundaries. By unifying independent Pentecostal bodies under the centralized EFGBC, he explicitly reframed executive leadership from a secular administrative post into a messianic assignment (Østebø, 2025, p. 70)(Gardner, 2024, p. 49).

Abiy's appointment in April 2018 occurred during widespread anti-government protests by youth movements, namely by the "Qeerroo" and "Fano" (Østebø, 2025, p. 65)(Gardner, 2024, pp. 87, 105).[5] To signal political change to the youth in 2018-2019, he executed a major institutional and political overhaul by formally dissolving the EPRDF coalition, formally reconciliating with Eritrea, and subsequently establishing the Prosperity Party. The creation of this party restructured the mechanics of state authority, replacing the federal coalition of semi-autonomous regional fronts with a unitary party structure. This centralizing drive precipitated a rupture within the

[5]Youth movements in Ethiopia are a distinct political power, their influence, as well as the inherent broader ethnic-federal debate in Ethiopian politics was decidedly not included in this working paper, for further information see: Tesfaye and Kefale (2025), Abebe (2020), Ishiyama (2023), Taye (2017).

ruling elite. Especially the Tigrayan People's Liberation Front (TPLF) rejected the merger as an unconstitutional usurpation of regional autonomy, withdrawing from the national coalition and severing formal relations between Mek'ele and Addis Ababa (Gardner, 2024, pp. 216, 230).

To counter potential isolation and build a broader power base, Abiy employed widespread political, social, and economic patronage. Prominent Oromo business leaders and political figures were offered stakes, land leases, and development contracts within capital projects in Addis Ababa and surrounding areas (Gardner, 2024, p. 88, 209). Amhara political elites and urban classes were won over through the public rehabilitation of imperial historical symbols, including the restoration of Emperor Menelik II's palace, the inauguration of Unity Park, and the construction of state monuments celebrating the Battle of Adwa (Gardner, 2024, pp. 90, 210). Through this combination of messianic narrative, party restructuring, and executive control, the state moved away from its previous multinational federal structure toward a centralized political model around Abiy himself (Gardner, 2024, pp. 213, 218, 336).

Moreover, Abiy introduced an architectural makeover of Addis Ababa, which serves as the central physical manifestation of his political authority and vision for the "New Ethiopia". Huge capital investments finance mega-projects such as Beautifying Sheger, Unity Park, Entoto Park, or the Chaka Palace complex (Gardner, 2024, pp. 2, 135ff., 204, 328). This procedure operates under a logic of "aesthetic sovereignty", wherein public spaces and modern monuments project a visual image of state capability. Rooted in the principles of neuroaesthetics and environmental psychology, the regime posits that physical surroundings directly alter civic consciousness, driving national productivity and attracting international capital (Østebø, 2025, p. 77f.). This transformation is accompanied by explicit imagery, for instance billboards portraying Abiy overlooking the capital, visually signaling that the person and the apparatus of the state have become conceptually and structurally inseparable (Gardner, 2024, p. 203).[6]

Further, at the core of the state's new economic policy lies "Prosperity Capitalism", fusing neoliberal market ideas with an individualized doctrine of self-actualization (Gorski and Perry, 2022, p. 38)(Østebø, 2025, p. 74). Within this framework, Abiy presents his own trajectory as the national archetype: "I am the New Ethiopia" (Abiy Ahmed as in Gardner, 2024, p. 205). National development and personal upward mobility are articulated not as functions of structural state

[6]For reference, see: (Figure 4: Billboard in Addis Abeba).

planning or redistributive policy, but as matters of pure willpower, psychological discipline, and hard work. State rhetoric repeatedly forecasts imminent Ethiopian wealth, positioning the nation on a trajectory toward economic success. This worldview materializes through "Pentecostal mercantilism", a system of oligarchic patrimonialism wherein commercial elites and developers are granted privileged access to prime urban land and public sector contracts in exchange for financial contributions and political loyalty. In this environment, corruption ceases to be an institutional malfunction, instead it operates as a deliberate feature of governance, used to sustain a loyal corporate-political elite (Gardner, 2024, pp. 209, 329).

Moreover, the novel governing philosophy of "Medemer" (መደመር)[7] operates through strategic vagueness, serving as an elastic ideological container that can be repurposed according to executive necessity (Gardner, 2024, pp. 66, 212, 215). In its initial public formulation, Medemer adopted a secular, inclusive posture, avoiding explicit confessional references, invoking generic Amharic terms for the divine, accommodating non-Christian traditions and framing itself as compatible with the existing federal order (Østebø, 2025, p. 69f.)(Gardner, 2024, p. 49).[8]

Behind this inclusive exterior, Medemer functions as a tool for mental re-engineering. Influenced by wealthy Evangelical diaspora networks and secular self-help paradigms, the philosophy displays hostility toward secularism or socialist idea (Gardner, 2024, pp. 45f., 206). Structural poverty and underdevelopment are re-articulated as psychological defects stemming from negative thinking. Officials and military leadership are required to participate in televised, sermon-like training sessions designed to purge "negative mindsets" and eliminate the language of poverty from public discourse (Gardner, 2024, p. 206). This sacralized statecraft is illustrated in, e.g., Abiy's Easter address, where national political trajectories were framed through resurrection rhetoric:

> "Ethiopia is currently witnessing its own resurrection despite a long and challenging journey. The nation has loosened its shroud, opened its tomb, and torn its seal. The country is moving toward an ascension with no turning back." (Abiy Ahmed as in Gardner, 2024, p. 71)

Under Medemer, synergy is elevated to the supreme organizing principle of national identity and political economy, positioning alternative class, ethnic, or localized identities as impediments

[7] Translation: "Synergy" or "Togetherness".

[8] Abiy wrote four books in his Medemer series so far, with the latest (The Medemer State) focusing on institutionalizing the philosophy into a governance model. For reference, see the first: (Figure 3: Medemer).

to national progress. The consolidation of the Prosperity Party as a highly centralized political apparatus marked the formal dismantling of institutional pluralism (Østebø, 2025, p. 65). Political dissent and armed resistance are confronted with state force or civil conflict, reflecting a wider project aimed at the comprehensive social re-engineering of polity and subsequently the entire state. Within this framework, scheduled electoral processes serve primarily as non-competitive mechanisms designed to confirm executive control rather than democratic freedom (Gardner, 2024, p. 305f.). As formal political opposition, press freedom, and civil society institutions are systematically curtailed, religious communities have emerged as one of the few remaining spaces for collective expression. However, these spaces are themselves increasingly drawn into state alignment, as religious affiliations intersect with broader ethnic, economic, and regional dynamics.

4. Modern Ethiopian Nationalism

Christian nationalism inherently establishes a hierarchy of civic belonging, casting religious minorities as ideological threats or secondary citizens (Gorski and Perry, 2022, p. 14). In Ethiopia, where the historical fabric is mainly divided among Orthodox Christians, Muslims, and Protestants, the state's implicit and explicit Pentecostal tilt has exacerbated inter-communal friction (Haustein, 2013, p. 348)(Gardner, 2024, p. 224)(Østebø, 2025, p. 63). While Abiy initially employed inclusive rhetoric his actual administration has frequently alienated both Muslim and traditional Orthodox communities. Tensions within the Muslim community intensified over state involvement in the EIASC, while severe violent episodes, such as attacks on mosques in Gondar and Mota, highlighted the vulnerability of minorities under a sacralised state framework (Gardner, 2024, pp. 178, 336). Concurrently, conservative Orthodox factions often view Pentecostal dominance with acute suspicion and fears of deepening social polarization (Gardner, 2024, pp. 186, 224). Although Article 11 of Ethiopia's 1995 Constitution explicitly mandates the separation of state and religion, Abiy openly discarded this boundary, publicly stating that constitutional separation "doesn't mean they shouldn't work together" (Abiy Ahmed as in Gardner, 2024, p. 49)(Østebø, 2025, p. 69). By declaring that his ultimate ambition was to expand the kingdom of god, Abiy reframed national governance into a theological mission, eroding the institutional foundations of secular pluralism.

In addition, under such an ideology, traditional patriarchal authority is sacralised as essential to social stability, framing gender equality and feminist frameworks as foreign corruptions (White-

head and Perry, 2020, p. 76). Although the Ethiopian government initially gained international praise for appointing high-profile female cabinet members, underlying political philosophy remains firmly rooted in patriarchal traditionalism (Gardner, 2024, pp. 145, 205, 305). Former government officials reported that senior executive leadership actively dismissed feminist concerns and structural gender policies, subordinating women's rights to moralized family narratives and traditional social roles (Gardner, 2024, pp. 205, 305).

LGBTQ+ populations also bear a heavy burden under such governance, as sexual minorities are routinely positioned as indicators of societal decline (Whitehead and Perry, 2020, p. 59f.). In Ethiopia, the rise of Pentecostal statecraft coincided with a notable surge in state-sanctioned and socially weaponised hostility (Gardner, 2024, p. 305). Homosexual acts remain heavily criminalised, with up to fifteen years imprisonment. Government institutions and state-backed media platforms have actively stoked homophobic panics, depicting LGBTQ+ rights as imperialist encroachments designed to dismantle the nation's spiritual fabric (Gardner, 2024, p. 305).

Furthermore, the enshrined social contract between state and society is also being replaced by systems with individualist, moralized doctrines of self-reliance. Under this influence systemic socio-economic hardships are rearticulated as individual psychological failures or spiritual deficits. The current administration explicitly discourages public discourse regarding structural poverty, with Abiy instructing officials to cease talking about it, claiming that focusing on it perpetuates economic failure (Gardner, 2024, p. 206)(Østebø, 2025, p. 76). Institutional welfare safety nets and developmental state mechanisms are de-emphasised in favour of voluntary street-cleaning initiatives, national tree-planting campaigns, or individualist self-help programs (Gardner, 2024, pp. 60, 206). Consequently, state responsibility for social vulnerability is transferred onto citizens, who are instructed to adjust their "mindsets" rather than demand redistributive policies.

The most profound impact of Christian nationalism in Ethiopia lies in the erosion of democratic governance. By framing political struggles as conflicts between good and evil, democratic compromises, parliamentary deliberation, and institutional checks and balances are discarded as obstacles to divine purpose (Gardner, 2024, pp. 207, 308). Under Abiy, governance shifted from the EPRDF's collective party apparatus to a deeply personalized, autocratic executive model. Cabinet meetings were reduced to abbreviated sessions where executive decisions were handed down without deliberation (Gardner, 2024, p. 207)(Østebø, 2025, p. 78). Crucially, when political disputes escalate, the state frames these conflicts in explicitly holy terms. Warfare is cast as a

necessary purification process, with the Prime Minister and state-aligned clergy invoking biblical martyrdom, declaring that "God is in our company" and predicting total victory through divine intervention (Gardner, 2024, pp. 308, 314)(Østebø, 2025, p. 71). Dehumanizing rhetoric issued by top advisors demonstrates how sacralized statecraft can lead to devastating civil conflict and human rights violations.

5. Conclusion & Discussion

The evolution of Christian nationalism in modern Ethiopia demonstrates its capacity to transform a secular, ethnic-federal state system into a majoritarian, providential regime (Gorski and Perry, 2022, p. 14)(Whitehead and Perry, 2020, p. 57)(Gardner, 2024, p. 213). As evidenced by this context, when statecraft is sacralised through theology, the institutional mechanics of secular governance, social welfare, and democratic pluralism are fundamentally restructured or dissolved (Gardner, 2024, pp. 4, 49, 206)(Østebø, 2025, pp. 63, 78).

Furthermore, as per Haustein (2013) critical historiography demonstrates that religious "truth" is not an immutable, static entity preserved in history. Rather, it is a perpetually constructed and re-emplotted narrative. Early Ethiopian Pentecostalism emphasized personal salvation, strict asceticism, and distance from state politics. However, as the movement expanded through the post-1991 era, its theological core was systematically re-emplotted (Haustein, 2013, p. 350f.)(Østebø, 2025, p. 67). Under the influence of economic-theological doctrines and North American prosperity gospel ideas Pentecostalism was transformed into a tool of political manifestation. Faith was no longer interpreted as a refuge from the state, but as a divine mandate to occupy it. Thus, a search for an essential, static "truth" of P'ent'ay misses the reality that religious meaning is continuously negotiated and re-authored by political actors seeking to align sacred authority with contemporary political goals (Haustein, 2013, p. 350f.)(Whitehead and Perry, 2020, p. 58).

In addition, hegemonic political-religious narratives rarely disintegrate when challenged, instead, they undergo a process of discursive recycling (Haustein, 2013, p. 350). Because central ideological concepts function as empty signifiers, state actors possess significant capabilities to re-encode them, if confronted by popular resistance or institutional crises. In Ethiopia, when the initial narrative of inclusive, non-violent civic reform faced armed confrontation by the TPLF, the state narrative did not collapse. Instead, the executive apparatus adapted and rhetoric shifted from synergy to existential, spiritual warfare for the "new syngery" of reuniting all of Ethiopia, casting

military campaigns as divinely ordained trials necessary to cleanse the nation of internal subversion (Gardner, 2024, p. 276)(Østebø, 2025, p. 71). Strategic ambiguity allowes the principle of Medemer to absorb contradictory demands, presenting itself simultaneously as a defense of traditional pan-Ethiopian heritage and as a modern, forward-looking economic paradigm. By framing political authority as a divine mandate, Christian nationalism marginalises vulnerable populations and transforms political disputes into existential conflicts.

While sharing structural features with Christian nationalism in the United States of America, such as the sacralization of executive authority or the erosion of secular boundaries, Ethiopian Pentecostal statecraft represents a distinct model. It combines a historically minority faith with executive power, utilizing top-down urban transformation, corporate management concepts, and imperial historical symbols to build a centralized state apparatus (Gardner, 2024, pp. 44, 204). By labelling economic and social success as a spiritual endeavor or mission, this model reinterprets structural poverty as a mental limitation, marginalizes alternative political identities, and transforms civil disputes into existential conflicts (Gardner, 2024, pp. 206, 252)(Østebø, 2025, p. 76). The study of P'ent'ay statecraft in Ethiopia illustrates the profound structural consequences that emerge when political power is claimed in the name of a divine purpose.

Appendix

Figure 1: Logo of the EFGBC (Ethiopian Full Gospel Believers' Church, 2026)

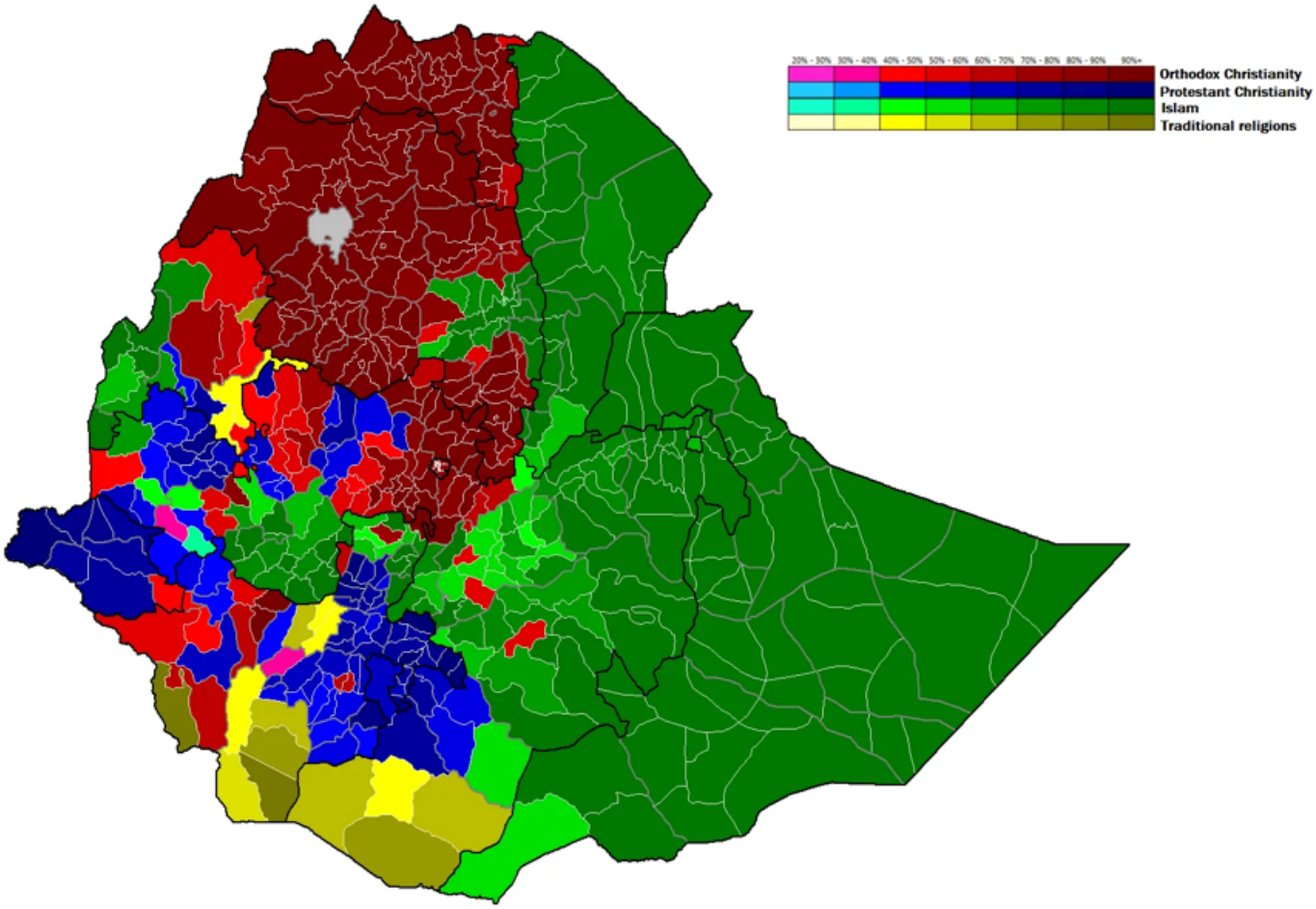


Figure 2: Religion in Ethiopia (Lewis, 2021)

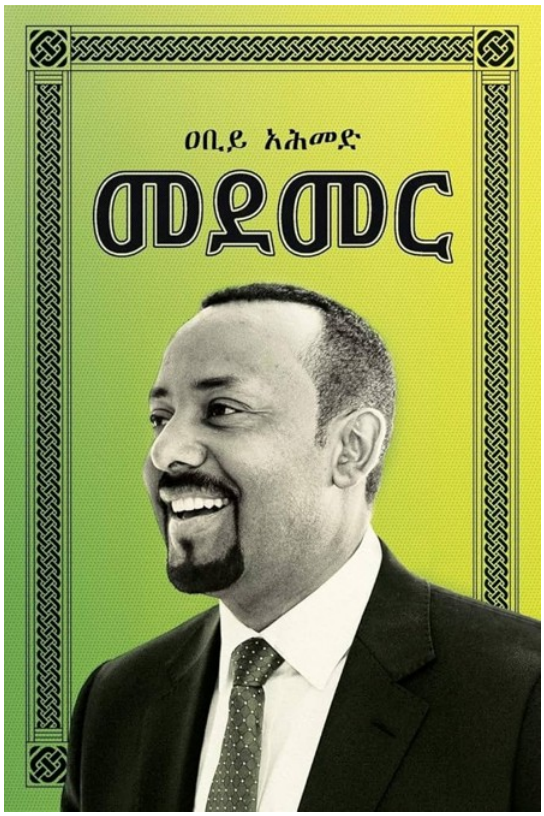


Figure 3: Medemer (Abiy Ahmed Ali, 2019)



Figure 4: Billboard in Addis Ababa (Byrono, 2026)

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